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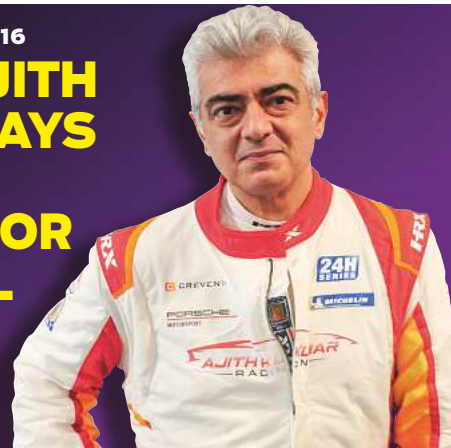
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KUMAR SAYS
HE DOES
RACING FOR
THE SOUL**



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**Aramex shares up
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INDIA'S 'KUMBH MELA': HUMANITY'S BIGGEST GATHERING KICKS OFF

Pilgrims walk through a pontoon bridge as they arrive to take a dip in sacred waters as the Kumbh Mela festival opened yesterday, with organisers expecting 400 million people — the largest gathering of humanity. The millennia-old festival is held at the site where the Ganga, Yamuna and mythical Saraswati rivers meet. **SEE ALSO P12**

NATION

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launches 'most
innovative and
premium school'
in Dubai | P4**

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**India opens
strategic
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tunnel to border
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Gaza deal can be done this week, US says

QATARI EMIR MEETS BIDEN, TRUMP'S
MIDEAST ENVOYS TO DISCUSS TRUCE

WASHINGTON/DOHA

A Gaza truce and hostage release deal is close and could be finalised in the final week of US President Joe Biden's term, White House National Security Advisor Jake Sullivan said yesterday. "We are close to a deal, and it can get done this week. I'm not making a promise or prediction, but it is there for the taking, and we are going to work to make it happen," Sullivan told reporters.

In a related development, Qatari Emir Shaikh Tamim Bin Hamad Al Thani and a delegation from the Palestinian militant group headed by lead negotiator Khalil Al Hayya discussed "developments in the ceasefire negotiations in the Gaza Strip, which aim to achieve a long-term truce", his office said in a statement.

The Emir also met with Steve Witkoff, US President-elect Donald Trump's expected Middle East envoy, and Brett McGurk, the incumbent Joe Biden's envoy for the region, the emir's office said in a separate statement.

Meanwhile, talks between Israeli and Hamas envoys to pause the 15-month war in Gaza are

making progress, with negotiations under way to release hostages in exchange for Palestinian prisoners and deliver a boost to humanitarian aid.

Israeli officials say they've presented a detailed outline to Hamas in a second day of discussions in Doha and are awaiting approval for final talks. A Hamas official agreed that a deal is closer than ever.

The goal is a framework, if not a completed agreement, by Donald Trump's inauguration as US president next Monday. Talks overseen by the outgoing administration of Joe Biden have foundered for months, during which fighting has continued at various levels of intensity and much of the territory of more than 2 million people has been reduced to rubble. —Agencies

SEE ALSO P10

Israeli officials say they've presented a detailed outline to Hamas in a second day of discussions in Doha and are awaiting approval for final talks.

No added costs for UAE gold shoppers from new VAT rules

Revised regulations set to benefit business-to-business transactions

DUBAI

BY MANOJ NAIR
Business Editor

Gold and jewellery buyers in the UAE can shop knowing that the Ministry of Finance's new VAT rules come at no additional costs to them. Consumers will continue paying the 5 per cent VAT as before, while tourists remain eligible for VAT refunds on exit, jewellery retailers reassure shoppers.

The revised rules, applying the 'Reverse Charge Mechanism' to the precious metals and stones sector, primarily benefit business-to-business transactions, easing cash flow and compliance for wholesalers and retailers. Retail jewellers now act as tax collectors on behalf of the government, collecting VAT from customers while simplifying processes for suppliers.

"This doesn't impact shop-

Dh301.75
price of 22K gold
per gram in the UAE
yesterday

pers directly; the changes focus on business-level transactions," clarified Girish Chand, Senior Partner at MCA Management Consultants.

Gold prices remain elevated at \$2,689 an ounce, with 22K gold priced at Dh301.75 per gram in the UAE. Despite high prices, jewellery retailers like Joy Alukkas view the VAT adjustment as a step toward smoother operations.

The Ministry of Finance reaffirmed its commitment to supporting the precious metals and gemstones trading sector. By reducing administrative burdens, the rules aim to foster business growth while ensuring consumer costs remain unchanged.

SEE ALSO P6

Dubai deploys drones to enhance safety

Move aims to boost emergency response in densely populated high-rise areas

DUBAI

BY ASHFAQ AHMED
Senior Assistant Editor

In a first for the region, Dubai Police have deployed drones in a high-rise district to improve public safety. Dubai Multi Commodities Centre (DMCC) — a leading business district driving global trade through Dubai — has joined forces with Dubai Police to expand its innovative drone network, aiming to improve safety and situational awareness across two of the city's key business districts: Uptown Dubai and Jumeirah Lakes Towers (JLT).

The Drone Box system

marks a significant leap forward in the integration of smart technologies for urban safety and enhances emergency response capabilities, especially in densely populated, high-rise environments.

Ahmad Bin Sulayem, Executive Chairman and CEO of DMCC, commented: "The Drone Box system is among the most advanced drone technologies globally, playing a pivotal role in boosting public safety in Dubai. Its deployment across JLT and Uptown Dubai is a significant milestone, underscoring our ongoing commitment to offering the best possible experience in these vibrant communities."

The system, developed by Ondas Autonomous Systems, is certified by the US Federal Aviation Administration (FAA) and is one of the most advanced technologies in use today.



SPORT

**22-year-old
Bhatia carries
American
hopes in
Dubai | P13**

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